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Researching Masonic Ancestors

July 2025

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TAGS

#familyhistory #genealogy #grapevinelibrary 72-year-rule cardinalroad census church records

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BY

NANCY
MAXWELL

· JULY 15,
2025



Perhaps you have a male relative who was a Freemason and a member of a US Masonic lodge. In today's blog we'll discuss how to research and document the Masonic relatives in your family tree.

civilwar civil war court records

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familyhistory FDR

federalcensus

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genealogy government

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revolutionary war SandyWall

serendipity trinityriver WPA



A Bri ef His tor y of Fre em aso nry

The
Freemasons
are the
world's
oldest
fraternal
organization.
The
general
consensus
among
Masonic
scholars
is that
they
started
with
medieval
stonemasons
who



built
British
castles
and
cathedrals.
During
the
Middle
Ages,
stonemasons
often
traveled
around
to find
work in
different
locations.
To
demonstrate
their
level of
qualification,
they
would
use
grips,
words,
and
signs to
distinguish
themselves
from
unqualified
builders.
Freemasonry
uses
building
analogies



to
teach
members
how to
lead
productive
lives
that
benefit
the
communities
that
they
live in.
Part of
the
Freemason's
outfits
includes
aprons
and
gloves.
This is
because
in the
medieval
era,
stonemasons
wore
aprons
and
gloves
to
protect
themselves
while
working
on



shaping
rough
pieces
of
stone.

Modern History of Freemasonry



The
biblical
account
of King
Solomon's
Temple
forms
the
symbolic
setting
for
Craft
Freemasonry's
origins.
Current

Freemasonry

dates

from

June

24,

1717.

Four

London

Lodges,

which

had

existed

for

some

time,

came

together

at the

Goose

and

Gridiron

Tavern

in St

Paul's

Churchyard

and

declared

themselves

a

Grand

Lodge.

This

was the

first

Grand

Lodge

in the

world.



The
Grand
Lodges
of
Ireland
Scotland
formed
in 1725
and
1736,
respectively.
Freemasonry
emphasizes
personal
study,
self-
improvement,
and
social
betterment
via
individual
involvement
and
philanthropy.
It's
open
to all
men of
good
reputation
who
profess
belief
in a
Supreme
Being
(referred



to in
the
lodge
as The
Supreme
Architect
of the
Universe).

By
1723,
the
new
Grand
Lodge
had
published
its first
rulebook,
*The
Constitutions
of the
Free-
Masons*
– and

was
meeting
quarterly
and
recording
its
meetings.
Interwoven
with
the
British
Enlightenment,
Masonic
lodges



formed
throughout
Europe
and the
Americas.

Freemasonry in North America



In
1732,
St.
John's
Lodge
No. 1 in
Boston,
Massachusetts
was
duly
constituted
by the
Grand
Lodge
of

England
and
remains
the
oldest
lodge
in
North
America.
Many
of the
founding
generation
were
Freemasons,
such as
George
Washington,
Benjamin
Franklin,
James
Monroe,
Ethan
Allen,
John
Jay,
John
Paul
Jones,
and
Paul
Revere.
Other
Freemasons
included
nine of
the
fifty-six



signers
of the
Declaration
of
Independence;
thirteen
of the
thirty-
nine
signers
of the
Constitution;
and
thirty-
three
of the
seventy-
four
generals
of the
Continental
Army.
In fact,
some
lodges
were
instituted
within
Continental
Army
units:

- St.
John's
Regimental
Lodge,
US
Battalion,
warranted



by
G.
L.
of
New
York,
24
Feb
1775

- American
Union
Lodge,
Connecticut
Line,
warranted

by
G.
L.
of
Massachusetts,
15
Feb
1776

- No.
19
in
1st
Regiment,
Pennsylvania
Artillery,
warranted
by
G.
L.
of
Pennsylvania,
18



May

1779

- Washington
Lodge,
Massachusetts
Line,
warranted
by
Massachusetts
G.
L.,
6
Oct
1779

- No.
20
in
North
Carolina
Regiment,
warranted
by
G.
L.
of
Pennsylvania,
1779

- No.
27
in
Maryland
Line,
warranted
by
G.
L.
of
Pennsylvania,



4

Apr

1780

- No.
28
in
Pennsylvania
Line,
warranted
by
G.
L.
of
Pennsylvania,
1780

- No.
29,
in
Pennsylvania
Line,
warranted
by
G.
L.
of
Pennsylvania,
27
Jul
1780

- No.
31,
in
New
Jersey
Line,
warranted
by
G.



L.
of
Pennsylvania,
26
Mar
1781

- No.
36,
in
New
Jersey
Line,
warranted
by
G.
L.
of
Pennsylvania,
2
Sep
1782



Regular
Freemasonry
is
defined
by
jurisdiction.
In
twenty-
four
states
members
are
part of
the
Ancient
Free
and

Accepted

Masons;

in

twenty-

five

states

they

are

part of

the

Free

and

Accepted

Masons.

In

South

Carolina

they

are the

Ancient

Free

Masons,

and in

the

District

of

Columbia

they

are the

Free

and

Accepted

Masons.

The

major

differences

are in

officer



titles
and
little
differences
in ritual
wordings.

Structure of Freemasonry



The
structure
of
Freemasonry
consists
of
three
degrees.
The
first is
initiation,
which
completes
the
First
Degree.
At this

point,
candidates
become
an
'Entered
Apprentice.'
This
reminds
Masons
that
that all
are
equal,
and it is
the
responsibility
of
those
that do
well to
look
after
those
less
fortunate.
In the
Second
Degree,
candidates
becomes
a
'Fellowcraft
Freemason.'
This
encourages
members
to
better



themselves
through
education
and
focuses
on self-
development.

The
Third
Degree
teaches
candidates
how to
use
their
lives
wisely
and be
remembered
for the
right
reasons.

On
completion
of the
Third
Degree,
the
candidate
become
a
Master
Mason.
You
might
see
references
to "Blue



Lodge”
at this
level; it
refers
to
these
three
degrees
of
Freemasonry.
Officers
of a
Masonic
Lodge
are
Worshipful
Master,
Senior
Warden,
Junior
Warden,
Treasurer,
Secretary,
Senior
Deacon,
Junior
Deacon,
and
Tiler.

Th
e
Gra
nd
Lo



dg
e

The
Grand
Lodge
in each
state
has
jurisdiction
over
the
local
lodges.
There
is no
national
headquarters.

The
Grand
Lodge
requires
reports
from
local
lodges,
such as
new
members,
affiliates,
demits,
and
deaths,
and
publishes
annual
Proceedings,



many
of
which
are
online
at
[Google](#)
[Books](#),
[HathiTrust](#),
[Internet](#)
[Archive](#),
and
other
digital
collections.

The
Grand
Lodge
may
have
an
archive
and
offer
genealogical
services.

They
also
have
web
sites
you
can
visit to
see
what
services
they



may
offer.
Figure
1
shows
the
origins
of each
Grand
Lodge,
along
with
the
individual
Lodges
that
formed
it. To
view
the
enlargeable
map,
click
[here](#).



*Fig. 1.
"Genealogy
of Masonic
Grand
Lodges of
the U.S."*

Pri
nce
Hal

I Fre em aso nry



Fig. 2.
Prince
Hall
(1735-
1807).

Founded
in
1784,
[Prince](#)
[Hall](#)
[Freemasonry](#)
is the
oldest
African
American
Masonic
order.
Prince
Hall
(Fig. 1)
was a
leather
merchant
who
owned



property
in
Boston
and
was
therefore
on the
city's
voting
roll. He
died in
1807.
In
1775,
after
Hall
and
other
free
Blacks
tried
unsuccessfully
to join
an all-
white
Masonic
lodge,
they
were
initiated
into
Lodge
441,
attached
to a
British
army
regiment.



When
the
British
retreated
from
Boston
in
1776,
Hall's
group
received
a
permit
to
assemble
as
African
Lodge
No. 1.
In
1784,
the
Grand
Lodge
of
England
officially
chartered
the
group
as
African
Lodge
No.
459. It
is now
known
as the



Worshipful
Prince
Hall
Grand
Lodge
of
Massachusetts.
There
are
over
4500
lodges
worldwide,
forming
over
forty-
seven
sovereign
Jurisdictions
with a
membership
of over
300,000
Masons
who
can
trace
their
origins
to
African
Lodge
No.
459.
You
can
trace
African



American
Freemasonry
in the
same
manner
as
White
Freemasonry.

Ext ens ion s of Ma son ic Bo die s

In
Freemasonry
there
are two
main
sets of
side
degrees
–
Ancient
and
Accepted



Scottish
Rite of
Freemasonry
and the
York
Rite.
Basically,
there is
no
Masonic
degree
more
important
than
that of
Master
Mason.
These
degrees
are
part of
a
system
of
further
Masonic
education,
spread
out
over
twenty-
nine
degrees
that
expand
upon
and
elaborate



teachings
and
lessons
of first
three
degrees.

The
Scottish
Rite
refers
to the
type of
Masonry
practiced
rather
than to
native
Scotsmen.

The
Grand
Lodge
oversees
the first
through
third
degrees,
and the
Supreme
Council
oversees
the
fourth
through
thirty-
third
degrees.
It has
Northern



and
Southern
jurisdictions
for
administrative
efficiency.

The
York
Rite is
derived
from
city of
York,
where,
according
to one
Masonic
legend,
the first
meetings
of
Masons
in
England
took
place.

Along
with
the
local
craft
lodge,
it
comprises
three
separate
and
distinct



bodies
each
with
degrees
and
rituals
to
achieve
spiritual
enlightenment
and
understanding.

These
include
the
Royal
Arch
Chapter
(Capitular
Masonry),
the
Council
of
Royal &
Select
Masters
(Cryptic
Masonry),
and the
Commandery
of the
Knights
Templar.

Shriners
International,
formally
known
as



Ancient
Arabic
Order
of the
Nobles
of the
Mystic
Shrine,
is an
American
Masonic
society
established
in 1870
and
headquartered
in
Tampa,
Florida.
Initially
known
as
“Shriners
North
America,”
the
name
was
changed
to
“Shriners
International”
in
2020. It
is a
fraternity
based
on fun,



fellowship,
and
Masonic
principles
of
brotherly
love,
relief,
and
truth.

About
200
Shriner
temples
are
located
across
North
America,
South
America,
Europe
and
Southeast
Asia.

They
are
known
for
their
philanthropy,
founding
the
Shriners
Hospitals
for
Children,
now





Kouyoujian, Xorine				✓
Birthdate	Birthplace	Birthdate	Birthplace	
Matthien	Zylster	Matthien	Matthien	
			1929-1-2	
Label	Label	Label	Label	
Kornbaga	1900-1-2-5	1947-1-1-5	1947-1-1-5	
Birthdate	Birthdate	Birthdate	Birthdate	
1947-3-10	1947-3-10	1947-3-10	1947-3-10	
			1977-12-22	
Records off. crechechawind 1977-2-5 (10-12-27)				

<https://grapevinelibrary.info/2025/07/researching-masonic-ancestors/>

Massachusetts

membership

card.

As with
all
genealogical
research,
Masonic
research
starts
at
home.
Look
for
Masonic
memorabilia,
regalia,
and
other
indications
of
Masonic
membership.
Check
with
other
relatives
and ask
about
possible
Masonic
membership
in their
families.
Contact
the
local
lodge if



you
know it,
as well
as the
Grand
Lodge
of that
state.
Ancestry.com
and
Ancestry
Library
Edition
have
digital
images
of
membership
cards
of the
Grand
Lodge
of
Massachusetts
under
“Massachusetts,
U.S.,
Mason
Membership
Cards,
1733-
1990.”
(Fig 3)
The
Grand
Lodge
of
Maine



[membership](#)

[cards](#)

are
also
online.

Information
from
the
Grand
Lodge
usually
includes
the
name
of the
lodge,
dates
of
Masonic
Degrees,
age,
occupation,
date of
death,
and if
the
Mason
remained
in good
standing.
It might
include
information
relating
to
offices
held
within



the
lodge
or
other
lodge
activities,
but
that's
not
usually
the
case. It
also
typically
doesn't
include
biographical
data,
family
members,
photographs,
or
information
relating
to
membership
in
Scottish
Rite,
Shriners,
York
Rite, or
similar
fraternal
organizations.
Grand
Lodges
may



have
request
information
on
their
web
sites
and
may
charge
for
research
and
copies.
Figures
4 and 5
show
Texas
Masonic
membership
cards
and a
Texas
Masonic
widow's
certificate,
obtained
from
the
Grand
Lodge
of
Texas.



Fig. 4.

Robert

Lafaye

tte Cox

Mason

ic

memb

ership

cards;

Leon,

Oenavi

lle,

and

Troy

Lodges

,

Texas.





Fig. 5.

Elizabeth Ann
(Amy)
Cox,
widow
of
Robert
Lafayette
Cox,
Texas
Masonic
widow's
certificate,
1911.



Also
check
newspaper
databases
such as
Newspapers.com,
NewspaperArchive.com,
GenealogyBank.com,
and
NewsBank.
All
except
GenealogyBank
are
available
free at



Fig. 6.

*Centennial
celebration,
Hancock
Lodge,
Greenfield,
Indiana.
The Daily
Reporter,
June 17,
1950.*

the
Grapevine
Library.
Many
kinds
of
Masonic
activities
have
been
reported
in
newspapers,
including
obituaries
and
feature
articles
such as
charity
work,



groundbreaking,
installation
of
officers,
etc.
(Fig. 6)

Look
for
county
histories,
as they
usually
have
information
on
fraternal
organizations
and
may
even
list
member
names.

(Fig. 7)
Some
state
and
individual
lodge
histories
have
been
published
as well.

(Fig. 8)

Masonic
records



may
also be
held at
county
archives
or
historical
or
genealogical
societies
and
libraries.

Most of
the
time
they
are
archived
by the
name
of the
lodge.

Remember
that
not
everything
is
online!

Your
research
may
involve
a trip
to
other
facilities
in
order



to
obtain
the
information
you're
looking
for.
Take
advantage
of the
opportunity
when it
comes.

[illegible]

Fig. 7. From Lancaster County, Pennsylvania: A History, vol. 4 (1924).



Fig. 8.
Images of
America:
New Jersey's
Masonic
Lodges
(2019)

Another
item to
keep in
mind is
that
most
lodge
records
don't
go back
as far
as
Freemasonry's
eighteenth-
century
origins.
Tragically,
many
have
been
lost to
fires; all
of the
California
Grand
Lodge's
records
burned
after
the
1906
San
Francisco
earthquake,
and
Arkansas
Grand
Lodge



lost its
records
on
August
27,
1919 in
a fire
that
destroyed
its
seven-
story
Masonic
Temple
in Little
Rock.

Whether
you
keep
Masonic
paraphernalia
or not,
scan
photos
and
documents
you
find
and
take
pictures
of
artifacts.
Do all
you
can to
identify
and



preserve
your
family's
Masonic
heritage.



Tags:

- #familytree
- #freemasonry
- #grandlodge
- #masoniclodge
- #squareandcompass
- grapevinelibrary


**YOU
MAY
ALSO
LIKE...**



H R L
i e i
s s n
t e k
o a O
r r l
i c d
c h M
a i a
l n p
C g s
o l a
u n n
n d d
t e L
y n a
A t n



t u d
l r R
a e e
s d c
e S o
s e r
a r d
n v s
d a t
P n o
l t Y
a s o
t u
B r
o 15, C
o 2026
o e
k n
s e

a
OCTOBER
31, 2022

o
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y
w
i
t
h
H
i
s
t
o
r
y
G
e
o

MARCH
16,
2022





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